

Boston Sunday Globe

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UK has more nuanced view of infanticide

Laws provide leniency for mothers who kill a child during postpartum period

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

The horror of the crime stunned a nation: Three weeks after giving birth to her second child, Brenda Hale, described as a happily married housewife, killed her baby and tried to kill herself.

“I only want to die,” a note police found in her hand read. “Can’t I be quietly put away?”

A major media event at the time,

the trial of Hale, of Hertfordshire, England, in July 1936 ended with the jury deciding not to convict the 26-year-old of murder. Critical to the verdict was testimony by an eminent physician that the mother suffered from “puerperal insanity,” mental illness brought on by childbirth, and wasn’t responsible for her actions.

The case led England and Wales to establish statutes that allow

courts to treat infanticide differently from other homicides, offering the possibility of leniency to mothers who kill a child during the postpartum period, the first year of the child’s life. Verdicts or pleas under that law almost never lead to prison time; commitment for mental health treatment is common.

Those statutes, still in place today, influenced similar laws in roughly two dozen countries.

In the United States, only Illinois has adopted a law that grants special consideration to mothers suffering from postpartum mental illness

who kill their children — but only during sentencing after a guilty finding.

Massachusetts and several other states have considered similar laws. The first-degree murder trial of Lindsay Clancy for killing her three children, Cora, 5; Dawson, 3; and Callan, 8 months, has revived debate about whether states should adopt some version of the nearly century-old English law.

“The criminal justice system needs to be updated to understand this illness,” said Jessie Colbert, co-

INFANTICIDE, Page A14

Big Apple envy over Mamdani’s fast start

Some activists wish for similar energy in Boston

By Janelle Nanos
GLOBE STAFF

NEW YORK — The air was thick with horns, chants, and the pungent aroma of summer in Manhattan as New York City Mayor Zohran Mamdani stepped up to a microphone strategically positioned under the claws of a giant inflatable rat.

Some 300 hospitality workers had gathered outside the Port Authority bus terminal, picketing for a union contract at the Four Points by Sheraton hotel in Times Square. New York City was in the grip of a heat emergency the first week of July, and it was sweltering. But Mamdani looked unflappable and untouched by the heat (not to mention the rat) after a day spent security planning for the tall ships’ arrival, ongoing World Cup matches, Fourth of July festivities, and the wedding of Taylor Swift and Travis Kelce at Madison Square Garden.

No sweat, all smiles.

“How we doing? How we feeling?” Mamdani asked, before winding into a speech that worked the crowd into a frenzy and hit upon all the key te-

MAMDANI, Page A12



PHOTOS BY TAYLOR COESTER FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

Stanley Greene (right) clasped hands with a community member during a weekly peace walk through Dorchester.

Decades on, a constant voice for peace

Although shootings in Boston are well down from the early ’90s, Black ministers remain in the vanguard of the city’s efforts to contain violence

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

There used to be a homicide in Boston, on average, every 58 hours. A man was found beaten and strangled to death in Savin Hill Park one Saturday afternoon in July, a pregnant woman found shot in the face on Neponset Avenue a few hours later. The year was 1990.

And at the forefront of fighting this vicious scourge of violence were Black clergymen, working with residents, advocates, and police to help bring about a huge dip in street violence, in what was eventually dubbed the Boston Miracle.

Now, more than three decades later, homicides in Boston are down nearly 80 percent from 1990, with fewer shootings and assaults than comparable American cities.

Those statistics beg the question: What makes a city safe?

It’s an inquiry with a multifaceted — and sometimes elusive — answer that keeps local

STREET VIOLENCE, Page A8



Brother Jeffrey 4X spoke into a megaphone as participants walked down Bailey Street during the peace walk.



ANGELINA KATSANIS/ASSOCIATED PRESS/FILE

Mayor Zohran Mamdani, accompanied by Barack Obama, felt the love at a preschool.

Among tech tools, Flock strikes a nerve

Broadening backlash has towns rethinking cameras

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

From private residences to office buildings, stores of all kinds and even some public streets, the ever-present glare of surveillance cameras has become so routine that there isn’t all that much pushback against them.

That is until the arrival of cameras from Flock Safety used by local police along public roads triggered a backlash over privacy and civil liberty concerns, in part because law enforcement such as federal immigration agents have been able to access and share information from the cameras without first getting a warrant.

Dustin Weir has a Ring doorbell camera on his Tewksbury home, but he was surprised to learn his community had installed some 20 cameras from Flock at intersections around town. So he requested police provide an image of his Toyota Highlander that just one camera captured on a day he dropped his child off at school. From that it was easy enough for Weir to see how 20 such cameras arranged like a ring around Tewksbury could essentially document the patterns of his family life as he runs errands and other prosaic ventures.

CAMERAS, Page A13

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A close call

Sunday: Cloudy and humid.

High: 82-87. Low: 68-73.

Monday: Showers, stormy.

High: 78-83. Low: 67-72.

Sunrise: 5:38 Sunset: 8:03

Complete report, **A22.**

Deaths, **A16-21.**



The Society for Creative Anachronism creates a world in the woods of Maine. **B1.**

Beaches can feel off-limits to those who use wheelchairs, but some are accessible. **N11.**

The Globe Magazine is not publishing today. Puzzles are on **B8.**

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